



Response to Duress Alarms in Mental Health (Mental Health) Policy

Preamble

Consumer Participation

The Rockingham Peel Group (RKPG) recognises and fully supports the need for the patient and/or their primary carer to¹:

- Know and exercise their healthcare rights.
- Be engaged in their healthcare.
- Have access to information about treatment options.
- Participate in treatment decisions.
- Have access to information about agreed treatment plans.

Scope of Practice

It is the responsibility of each health care provider to ensure all patient care and therapeutic interventions they provide are within their individual scope of practice. Refer to the [RKPG Guidelines to Writing for Clinical Policy](#) for further information about Scope of Practice.

Purpose

The purpose of this policy is to identify the correct procedure of how to respond to a duress in the various areas of Peel and Rockingham Kwinana (PaRK) Mental Health Service.

Policy statement

- In the event of the activation of a duress alarm at Mimidi Park, the duress response team delegated for the shift will immediately provide emergency assistance, in a coordinated manner, ensuring safety and security for both patients and staff.
- Staff are to refer to the following policies and guidelines:
 - * [South Metropolitan Health Service \(SMHS\) Injury Management Policy](#)
 - * [SMHS Injury Management Procedure](#)
 - * [Combined Hazard or Incident Report CHoIR](#)
 - * [Department of Health \(DoH\) Clinical Incident Management Policy](#)

Mimidi Park Inpatient Unit

- All staff will wear a personal duress pendant at all times while on duty. Personal duress are allocated to all permanent staff.
- Agency and casual staff will be allocated a duress pendant on commencement of each shift. Shift Coordinator to ensure that allocated duress pendants are returned at the end of the shift.
- All staff are to write their name and duress pendant number on the whiteboard before going on to the (ward) unit for easier identification of the person activating the duress.
- A register of the allocation of the duress pendant is maintained and must be completed at the beginning and end of their shift.
- Testing of the individual pendants must be conducted at the commencement of each day shift by each staff member to ensure it is working.

RESPONSIBILITY				NATIONAL STANDARDS
First Issued	Oct 2010	Revisions	Jun 2019	National Standards 1, 5, 6
This version	Aug 2022	Revision Due	Aug 2025	
Responsibility of	Co-Directors Mental Health	Endorsed by	DCS/DONM	
Title	Response to Duress Alarms in Mental Health (Mental Health) Policy			

- Weekly check of the system will occur each Tuesday afternoon.
- Pendants identified as faulty must be immediately reported to the Shift Coordinator who will arrange an Empac to be completed and provide a functioning replacement. Emergency response procedures will be practised regularly through drills.
- All staff will be familiar with and orientated to the duress response procedures at Mimidi Park. They will be oriented by the shift Coordinator.
- Managers and supervisors are responsible for ensuring that appropriate staff (clinical and non-clinical) are issued with personal duress alarms when working in environments where they may be required.
- The Shift Coordinator will designate staff members to respond to a duress alarm at Mimidi Park. The name of the designated staff member will be clearly displayed on the staff allocation board in each area. A substitute staff member will be identified in the event that the initial nominee is undertaking duties away from the ward.
- Staff responding to duress alarms will not put themselves at risk and will wait until adequate staff/Security are present to assess and manage the situation.
- Only designated duress response team members will respond directly to the location of the emergency if emergency location is different from their work place.
- All other clinical and non-clinical staff will provide back up support for any emergency situation, supporting and supervising patients and visitors not involved in the incident. Other staff will not respond directly to the emergency unless requested to do so, or if they are in the immediate vicinity.
- Rockingham General Hospital (RGH) Security staff attending Mimidi Park following the duress alarm activation will be directed by the Shift Coordinator or delegate on arrival and their role in the emergency response will be directed by the duress response team.
- Following an incident involving the activation of the duress alarm, staff involved will complete all relevant documentation, including incident report (DATIX CIMS) and CHoIR if applicable and, patient's medical record, If indicated update patient alert status in psychiatric services online information system (PSOLIS).
- The Shift Coordinator or delegate/incident Coordinator is the person responsible for standing down the duress response when the incident is safety contained.
- The Shift Coordinator/incident Coordinator will facilitate immediate diffusing and support. Consideration should be given to the need to offer a more formal debriefing/ support session as desired by staff.

Rockingham Adult Community

- The duress panel is located on the wall in the utility area behind reception. If an alarm is activated the location will be displayed on this panel.
- All offices and reception areas are fitted with a duress alarms situated under the desk. The alarm requires both red buttons to be activated, this will sound the alarm and the location will be displayed on the panel and outside the office where the alarm was activated.
- Pull down alarms are also located on the walls throughout the building. These are activated by pulling the lever where indicated.
- There are also personal mobile duress alarms available for use in areas where no

RESPONSIBILITY				NATIONAL STANDARDS
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This version	Aug 2022	Revision Due	Aug 2025	
Responsibility of	Co-Directors Mental Health	Endorsed by	DCS/DONM	
Title	Response to Duress Alarms in Mental Health (Mental Health) Policy			

fixed alarm is situated. These duress alarms are available from the Team Leader or Triage Officer.

- All building alarms are tested on a 3 monthly basis by the external alarm monitoring company.
- Staff are to take appropriate safety measures when meeting with clients. This includes:
 - * Notifying reception staff and using designated safe interview rooms if the client poses any risk or is unknown to services.
 - * Ensuring a duress pendant is worn at all times.
 - * Advising colleagues of any potential situation/known risks.
 - * Where there are identified PSOLIS alerts/known risks, decision to be made prior to arranging assessment in regard to requesting Security attendance.
 - * Arranging a back-up plan e.g. confirm a signal to escalate response.
 - * Where possible having a colleague present for the interview.
 - * Refer to [RKPG Patient Interviews at Mental Health Sites Guideline](#) for conducting any interviews in mental health sites.
- If a duress alarm has been activated from an office, and when it has been determined that the duress alarm can be turned off and the re-set protocol can be undertaken, the re-set key is to be taken from the Utility Area behind reception and inserted in the push-button duress alarm under the desk of the room where the alarm has been activated, and turned 90 degrees, to re-set the alarm.
- The siren can be turned off at the front, or the back doors of the building, by entering the appropriate code on the keypad and pushing off. If a pull-down duress alarm has been used, it must be pushed back in place before the siren can be turned off and the system re-set. No additional procedure to re-set the system is necessary when a personal duress alarm has been activated.
- Prestige Alarms should be notified of any alarm activation by phoning 94404999. The location code will be required which is found in the key cupboard.

Catalpa Centre Building Community

(includes Intensive Day Therapy Unit (IDTU), Specialist Rehabilitation Team (SRT), and other staff permanently located in the building)

- Testing of the duress alarm system, including personal mobile alarms, is to be conducted every three months. The IDTU Coordinator ensures that this occurs.
- All staff working in the Catalpa Centre building are to be familiar with, and orientated to, the duress response policies and procedures at the Catalpa Centre building.
- Every IDTU staff member is issued a personal mobile duress alarm, to be worn while on the premises at the Catalpa Centre. SRT is issued 2 personal mobile duress alarms that are to be worn whenever conducting a group with clients in the SRT client area. Every office in the building has a push-button duress alarm under the desk. Group Rooms 1, 2, and 3, and the SRT staff room have a pull-down duress alarm on the wall.
- When the siren from a duress alarm is sounded, the wall panel at the reception area or the keypad of any external door of the building can be consulted to see in which room the duress alarm has been activated. A red light indicator on the ceiling panel

RESPONSIBILITY				NATIONAL STANDARDS
First Issued	Oct 2010	Revisions	Jun 2019	National Standards 1, 5, 6
This version	Aug 2022	Revision Due	Aug 2025	
Responsibility of	Co-Directors Mental Health	Endorsed by	DCS/DONM	
Title	Response to Duress Alarms in Mental Health (Mental Health) Policy			

above the door of the office or room will also be lit up if the duress alarm from that room has been activated.

- If a staff member's personal mobile alarm has been activated, the keypad of any external door will indicate the number of that personal mobile alarm that has been activated. A reference list of names of staff members and the corresponding personal mobile duress alarm number is kept by the IDTU Work Health and Safety (WHS) representative, Coordinator, and on the wall of the reception area.
- Following an incident involving the activation of the duress alarm, staff involved will complete all relevant paperwork, including documenting in patients' medical records and making a report in the DATIX and CHoIR reporting systems as appropriate.
- Debriefing, support, and review of clinical practice and the response process will be provided for staff as soon as possible following an incident involving a duress response.
- Prestige Alarms should be notified of any alarm activation by phoning 94404999. The location code will be required which is found in the key cupboard.

Peel Adult Community (PCMHS)

Duress Alarms

- All staff must familiarise themselves with the duress alarm system, specifically the location of alarms which may be located under the desk or on the wall.
- Where a room has no duress alarm and a personal alarm is required. The staff member will collect a personal duress alarm for use in areas of direct patient contact such as interview rooms and treatment room. The staff member must collect a personal duress pendant prior to the commencement of the contact with the patient.
- Staff to inform colleagues of the number on the alarm and which safe room they will be in.
- Any faults or activation issues should be immediately reported for repair and where necessary CHoIR completed.
- PCMHS endeavours to meet its Work Health and Safety responsibilities to protect staff and members of the public from harm by providing duress alarms wherever they have been assessed as necessary. This is to allow staff to call for immediate assistance when in a duress situation.
- Staff are to take appropriate safety measures when meeting with clients. This includes:
 - * Notifying reception staff and using designated safe interview rooms if the client poses any risk or is unknown to services.
 - * Ensuring a duress pendant is worn at all times.
 - * Advising colleagues of any potential situation/known risks
 - * Where there are identified PSOLIS Alerts/known risks, decision to be made prior to arranging assessment in regard to requesting Security attendance.
 - * Arranging a back-up plan e.g. confirm a signal to escalate response.
 - * Where possible having a colleague present for the interview.
 - * Familiarity with the duress alarm system.

RESPONSIBILITY				NATIONAL STANDARDS
First Issued	Oct 2010	Revisions	Jun 2019	National Standards 1, 5, 6
This version	Aug 2022	Revision Due	Aug 2025	
Responsibility of	Co-Directors Mental Health	Endorsed by	DCS/DONM	
Title	Response to Duress Alarms in Mental Health (Mental Health) Policy			

- In the case of immediate risk of harm to staff and other users of the clinic, the staff member should:
 - * Leave the room if possible.
 - * Activate the duress alarm.

Coordinating incidents

- Duress indicator panels are located in reception and in the corridors as indicated on the Duress Plan. When a duress alarm is activated the indicator panel will show the location of the alarm, giving the number of the room or closest zone to the activated Duress.
- The first person arriving at the scene should coordinate the incident. They should maintain this role to promote continuity and consistency for reporting and statements.
- If more than one person arrives at the same time, the more senior staff member should coordinate the incident.
- The Coordinator should:
 - * Assess the situation.
 - * Make a verbal intervention requesting the aggressor to desist.
 - * Assess the need for physical intervention. Any physical intervention should only occur if there is immediate risk of injury and should only be enacted if absolutely safe to do so.
 - * Organise clinicians into a concerted response. This includes nominating staff members to:
 - Talk to the aggressor if appropriate.
 - Notify the Police.
 - Supervise movement/care of others (visitors/staff/clients).
 - Guide Police to incident.
 - Inform Police about the incident and the current situation.
 - Deactivate alarms at control panel using identified key kept in main key cupboard in reception.
- Plan a debrief for staff and clients.
- Only the most senior clinician attending the incident is to decide when the siren from the duress alarm is to be turned off (e.g. ascertaining that the situation is a false alarm) and the re-set protocol can be undertaken.

Documentation

- Details of the incident should be recorded in the progress notes of the client's medical record and in CHoIR or DATIX as required.
- Police statements may also be required.

Older Adult Mental Health (Rockingham)

Duress alarm

- All staff must be orientated to the type and use of the duress system upon commencement of contract within Older Adult Mental Health buildings.
- All staff working with a patient or carer or undertaking interviews with patients or carers must collect a personal duress pendant to be used in the event of a threat to

RESPONSIBILITY				NATIONAL STANDARDS National Standards 1, 5, 6
First Issued	Oct 2010	Revisions	Jun 2019	
This version	Aug 2022	Revision Due	Aug 2025	
Responsibility of	Co-Directors Mental Health	Endorsed by	DCS/DONM	
Title	Response to Duress Alarms in Mental Health (Mental Health) Policy			

their safety. Staff are advised that some rooms will also have additional alarm systems such as pull down alarms.

- Staff should activate a duress alarm in any threatening situation with a client/ member of the public, where assistance is required.
- Any alarm not cancelled will go through to the Combined Monitoring Centre for response. The Combined Monitoring Centre will contact Sureguard Security to check the building if the alarm is triggered when the office is unmanned.

Duress alarms consist of: (OAMH Rockingham Building) See Appendix B

- Under desk strips - most office desks except:
 - * Reception.
 - * Psychology Room.
 - * Consultant Psychiatrist Room.
 - * CNS and Social Work Office.
- Pull Down Alarms in:
 - * Group Room.
 - * Team Leader Office.
 - * Psychiatric Registrars' Office.
 - * Medical Records Room.
 - * Communications Room.
- Button Alarm on Wall
 - * Connect and Recovery Modules (CaRM) Office.
 - * Nurses Room.
 - * Clinical Nurse Specialist (CNS) and Social Worker Office.
 - * Interview Room.
- Personal alarms on quick release straps are available in the Communications room. These work off sensors located in rooms and the corridors.
- The circumstances of the situation should be assessed prior to client contact to determine the potential risk of aggression.
- If interviewing in potential hostile situation staff should give thought to the use of the Group Room as this room has three methods of exit and two of ingress, should support be required or the Interview Room which has an internal and an external exit.
- Staff should also give thought to having two staff attend the interview. Staff should refrain from using offices for interviews.
- It is also recommended that staff conducting group therapy sessions should ensure they are wearing personal alarms.

Responding to a duress alarm

- When a duress is activated, an alarm will sound, alarm lights will come on and the Location Board in Reception will light up indicating the location of the alarm.
- On hearing the alarm, other staff members should first ensure safety of any client that is present in the building with them.
- All staff not with clients should go to reception (if it is safe to do so) to assess what assistance is needed and are responsible for making arrangements for the safety of any clients / other members of the public in the vicinity.

RESPONSIBILITY				NATIONAL STANDARDS
First Issued	Oct 2010	Revisions	Jun 2019	National Standards 1, 5, 6
This version	Aug 2022	Revision Due	Aug 2025	
Responsibility of	Co-Directors Mental Health	Endorsed by	DCS/DONM	
Title	Response to Duress Alarms in Mental Health (Mental Health) Policy			

- The 000 Emergency Police Response should be called immediately if the safety of any person is at risk or the situation is escalating
- The senior staff member attending is responsible for decision to:
 - * Evacuation of premises through alternate exit.
 - * Lockdown of the reception area.
 - * Attempting to prevent others from coming into danger.
 - * See protocol same as for Rockingham Adult MH senior staff coordinating duress and documentation except for nil key in reception to deactivation (code instead).
- Reception/admin staff should remove themselves from danger if possible and await directions from senior staff to call for emergency services if required.
- Reception staff are to ensure they retrieve the safety mobile phone with them in the event that the reception area has to be evacuated – this will provide them with a means of contacting support.
- **Staff should ensure the safety of themselves first and then the others in the building.**
- If the duress alarm is activated during office hours (08:30 to 16:30hrs), Combined Monitoring Centre will contact this office.
- To Activate the Duress Alarms:
 - * To Activate wall Duress Alarm Press both red buttons at same time and Alarm will sound.
 - * To Activate Wall Duress Alarm with lever, pull lever down and alarm will sound.
- To Deactivate Duress Alarms:
 - * To switch the alarm off enter known alarm code on alarm panel in reception and press OFF.
 - * To deactivate Wall Duress alarm turn the key until green colour appears in box. Alarm will continue to sound until code is entered on Alarm Panel in Reception.
 - * To Deactivate Wall Duress Alarm with Lever - push lever back. Alarm will continue to sound until code is entered on Alarm Panel in Reception.

Accidental activation of duress alarm

- Following the assessment that a false alarm has been activated during office hours; Reception or other staff member will contact Combined Monitoring Centre to inform them that it is a false alarm. The telephone number for the Combined Monitoring Centre is in a display booklet kept in the bottom draw of the filing cabinet near the security arming panel.
- After hours, the person responsible for mistakenly activating the alarm is responsible for contacting Combined Monitoring Centre.

Compliance monitoring

Compliance with this policy will be monitored by any clinical incidents via Datix.

RESPONSIBILITY				NATIONAL STANDARDS
First Issued	Oct 2010	Revisions	Jun 2019	National Standards 1, 5, 6
This version	Aug 2022	Revision Due	Aug 2025	
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Title	Response to Duress Alarms in Mental Health (Mental Health) Policy			

References

1. Australian Commission on Safety and Quality in Health Care (ACSQH). The National Safety and Quality Health Service Standards Safety and Quality Improvement Guide: Standard 1 Governance for Safety and Quality in Health Service Organisations. 2nd ed. (Version 2) 2021. Available from <https://www.safetyandquality.gov.au/our-work/assessment-to-the-nsqhs-standards/>

Links

[Combined Hazard or Incident Report CHoIR](#)
[Department of Health \(DoH\) Clinical Incident Management Policy](#)
[RKPG Patient Interviews at Mental Health Sites Guideline](#)
[South Metropolitan Health Service \(SMHS\) Injury Management Policy](#)
[SMHS Injury Management Procedure](#)

National Standards



RESPONSIBILITY				NATIONAL STANDARDS National Standards 1, 5, 6
First Issued	Oct 2010	Revisions	Jun 2019	
This version	Aug 2022	Revision Due	Aug 2025	
Responsibility of	Co-Directors Mental Health	Endorsed by	DCS/DONM	
Title	Response to Duress Alarms in Mental Health (Mental Health) Policy			

Appendix A

Pendant Activation Mimidi Park, RGH

A duress pendant can be activated in 2 different ways at Mimidi Park

STAFF ASSIST

PRESS the Guardian Duress Alarm Pendant button firmly. This alarm is intended for staff support only and not an emergency type situation.

THIS WILL NOT GO TO PAGER

This will create a low but audible alarm heard throughout Mimidi Park only. Check Wall Panels and Guardian Terminals for Pendant # and location where low level assistance is required

PRESS



FULL DURESS/ CODE BLACK

PULL the personal duress pendant. To do this, the PULL RING/TAG up while holding the pendant. Check Wall Panels and Guardian Terminals for Pendant # and location.

This will create an audible alarm heard throughout Mimidi Park and will also page Security and the Mimidi Response Team via pager. Use this for an URGENT response.

**PULL
UP!**



RESPONSIBILITY				NATIONAL STANDARDS
First Issued	Oct 2010	Revisions	NA	National Standards 1, 5, 6
This version	Aug 2022	Revision Due	Aug 2025	
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Title	Response to Duress Alarms in Mental Health (Mental Health) Policy			

Appendix B: Older Adult Mental Health Clinic Rockingham Types of Duress Alarm activators available in the clinic



Personal Pendant	Pull Down Room Alarm	Button Alarm on Wall	Under desk alarm bar
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RESPONSIBILITY				NATIONAL STANDARDS
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